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CUET UG

Political Science

India's External Relations

Official Syllabus · Politics in India Since Independence · Class 12 · CUET UG 2027 Cycle Notes

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Syllabus Alignment

Sub-topic	Official syllabus pointer (NTA CUET(UG) Political Science syllabus 2026, the current 2027 baseline — Politics in India Since Independence)	Skills the questions test
Nehru's foreign policy	Nehru's foreign policy — non-alignment, Panchsheel, anti-colonial diplomacy	Stating the principles, their milestones and their logic in a bipolar world.
The three wars	Sino-Indian war of 1962, Indo-Pak war of 1965 and 1971	Running each cause-war-treaty chain with dates, leaders and outcomes.
Nuclear programme and alliances	India's nuclear programme and shifting alliance in world politics	Tracking Pokhran 1974, the NPT refusal, and the drift from non-alignment to the 1971 Soviet treaty.

EXAM PATTERN

CUET UG pattern (NTA official information bulletin and syllabus, 2026 cycle — the current 2027 baseline): each subject paper carries **50 compulsory questions** in **60 minutes**, with +5 for every correct answer and −1 for every incorrect answer. This unit is chain country — cause, war, treaty — so practise each war as one unbreakable sequence and the treaties as name-year pairs.

Nehru's Foreign Policy: The Architecture of Independence

Free India inherited no army of diplomats and no tradition of foreign policy — Nehru built both from scratch, serving as his own foreign minister. His architecture rested on one refusal and three commitments, and every later event in this chapter tests how far that architecture could bend without breaking.

- **The refusal — no blocs in a bipolar world:**
  - By 1950 the world had split into two armed camps — the US-led Western bloc and the Soviet-led Eastern bloc — each demanding loyalty, bases and wars.
  - India's answer: **non-alignment** — join NEITHER camp, judge every issue on its merits, and keep the right to say yes or no independently.
  - **What it is NOT (the classic trap):** non-alignment is not neutrality. A neutral state stays passive on every issue; a non-aligned state takes POSITIONS — India backed decolonisation, opposed Suez 1956, and sided with Bangladesh's people in 1971.

- **The commitments:**
  - **Anti-colonial solidarity:** India championed independence movements across Asia and Africa — the 1955 **Bandung** Afro-Asian conference made Nehru the senior voice of the newly free world.
  - **Peaceful settlement:** disputes would go to negotiation and the UN, not to war — the principle India's own three wars would test.
  - **The Commonwealth solution:** India stayed in the Commonwealth as a REPUBLIC (1949 London declaration) — membership without dominion status, another Nehruvian first.
  - **Institutional voice:** UN peacekeeping participation and mediation (Korea) — a small power acting like a responsible world citizen.
- **Panchsheel — the five principles (29 April 1954):**
  - Signed with CHINA (the Tibet-region trade agreement's preamble) — five rules of co-existence: mutual respect for sovereignty and territorial integrity; mutual non-aggression; non-interference in internal affairs; equality and mutual benefit; peaceful co-existence.
  - **The irony every exam mines:** the treaty partner was the country that attacked India within eight years, making a mockery of principles one and two.
  - **Why it still matters:** Panchsheel became the NAM's moral vocabulary — the code of conduct the non-aligned world quoted for decades.
- **The NAM institutionalisation:**
  - Founding leaders: **Nehru (India), Nasser (Egypt), Tito (Yugoslavia), Sukarno (Indonesia), Nkrumah (Ghana)**.
  - **Belgrade, 1961:** the first Non-Aligned Movement summit — 25 countries; the movement became a standing third voice in world politics.
  - **The bargain it bought India:** arms, aid and technology from BOTH blocs — Western food and Eastern steel — while keeping the flag and the judgment independent.

THE HOUSEHOLD THAT REFUSES BOTH LANDLORDS

Two competing landlords own every shop on the street and want every tenant on their side — discounts for loyalty, evictions for defiance. One tenant buys from whoever offers the better price, signs no exclusivity deal with anyone, and still speaks up when either landlord bullies a neighbour. The mapping: landlords = the Cold War blocs; buying on merit = arms/aid from both sides (Soviet steel, American wheat); speaking up = India's anti-colonial campaigns. The tenant is NOT neutral about injustice — he is simply nobody's client. That is non-alignment.

The Sino-Indian War of 1962: The Fall of the Brotherhood

"Hindi-Chini bhai-bhai" — Indians and Chinese are brothers — was the slogan of the 1950s. October 1962 turned it into a national wound, and the syllabus lists this war first for a reason: it changed India's defence policy, its politics and its view of the world.

- **The ladder to war (learn each rung):**

- **1950 — Tibet absorbed:** China takes over Tibet, bordering India directly; Delhi protests weakly and accepts the fact.
- **1954 — Panchsheel:** the friendship treaty (see above) — good feeling at its peak.
- **Mid-1950s — the map quarrel:** China publishes maps claiming Indian areas; India objects. The core dispute has two fronts: **Aksai Chin** in eastern Ladakh (China quietly built a road through it linking Tibet to Xinjiang) and the **McMahon Line** in the North-East Frontier Agency (NEFA), which China never accepted.
- **1959 — the rupture:** Tibet revolts; the **Dalai Lama flees to India and is given asylum**; Beijing reads Delhi as hostile. Border clashes begin.
- **1960-62 — talks fail:** Nehru's "Forward Policy" posts small Indian units ahead of Chinese positions; neither side steps back.

- **The war (October-November 1962):**
  - **20 October 1962:** China attacks SIMULTANEOUSLY on both fronts — NEFA and Ladakh. The blitz shatters unprepared Indian defences; supplies never reached frozen forward posts.
  - **20 November 1962:** China declares a unilateral ceasefire and withdraws from NEFA — but **keeps Aksai Chin**, which remains Chinese-held to this day.
  - **The political casualty:** Defence Minister **V.K. Krishna Menon resigns** (Nehru's closest aide) — the first head claimed by the war.
  - **The national lessons:** the army was rebuilt and expanded; defence spending jumped; and the humiliation became the standard against which every later military event was measured.
- **The consequences beyond the battlefield:**
  - **Alliance logic shifted:** the US and UK airlifted emergency arms — India's first brush with Western military dependence.
  - **Domestic politics hardened:** criticism of Nehru's China policy grew; the army chief's authority rose; the myth of Panchsheel lay in ruins.
  - **The phrase to quote:** 1962 ended India's innocence about China — suspicion became permanent policy equipment.

The Indo-Pak War of 1965: Shastri's Trial

Nehru died in May 1964; **Lal Bahadur Shastri** inherited the Pakistan quarrel — and within eighteen months, a full war. Learn this one as a three-act chain.

- **Act one — the spark:**
  - **Rann of Kutch, spring 1965:** border clashes in the salt marshes; a British-brokered ceasefire cools it — but Pakistan reads India as still weak after 1962.
  - **August 1965 — Operation Gibraltar:** Pakistan infiltrates guerrillas into Kashmir to spark an uprising; Kashmiris do not rise; India strikes the infiltration routes.
- **Act two — the war (September 1965):**
  - Pakistan launches a armoured thrust at **Khem Karan** in Punjab (Patton tanks) while India drives toward **Lahore**; the biggest tank battles since World War II follow at **Asal Uttar** — India's defences bog the Pattons down in flooded sugarcane country.

- **The verdict on the ground:** India holds Kashmir and threatens Lahore; both sides claim victory, but Pakistan's strategic aim — seizing Kashmir — fails.

- **Act three — the peace and the price:**
  - **Tashkent Agreement (10 January 1966):** Soviet-brokered; India and Pakistan agree to return to pre-war positions — the status quo ante.
  - **11 January 1966: Shastri dies in Tashkent** of a heart attack, hours after signing — a national shock that becomes its own exam question.
  - **The consequence:** Indira Gandhi replaces him as Prime Minister — the next chapter's story begins here.

The Indo-Pak War of 1971: The Birth of Bangladesh

The third war was the only one India fought to a decisive, world-changing finish — and it began inside Pakistan's own politics. Learn the chain: crackdown → refugees → treaty → war → victory → Shimla.

- **The trigger — Pakistan's self-wound:**
  - **December 1970 elections:** Sheikh Mujibur Rahman's **Awami League** wins an absolute majority in Pakistan's parliament — but East Pakistanis are Bengalis, and the West Pakistani military refuses to hand them power.
  - **25 March 1971 — Operation Searchlight:** the army cracks down on Dhaka; mass arrests and massacres follow; Mujib is jailed. The political crisis becomes a liberation war (the **Mukti Bahini** resistance).
- **The refugee flood:**
  - **Nearly 80 lakh refugees** stream into India — West Bengal, Assam, Tripura buckle under camps; the burden becomes a humanitarian and economic emergency.
  - **India's dilemma:** absorb quietly (impossible at this scale) or act. Indira Gandhi tours world capitals for months seeking pressure on Pakistan — and buys time while the army prepares.
- **The alliance shift — the treaty (August 1971):**
  - The **Indo-Soviet Treaty of Peace, Friendship and Cooperation** — a **20-year** pact guaranteeing mutual consultation and support.
  - **Why it mattered:** with the USSR standing behind India, China and the US could not intervene freely; a US task force did enter the Bay of Bengal in December — and stayed symbolic.
  - **The exam phrase:** this treaty is the syllabus's "shifting alliance" — from solo non-alignment to a formal partnership born of necessity.
- **The war and the victory (3-16 December 1971):**
  - Pakistan strikes airfields in the west first (3 December); India responds on BOTH fronts — while the eastern command, with the Mukti Bahini, races to Dhaka.
  - **16 December 1971:** General Niazi surrenders **93,000** prisoners in Dhaka — the largest surrender since World War II; **Bangladesh is born**.
  - **The verdict:** India's first clear-cut victory; non-alignment bent into a Soviet partnership without breaking; Indira Gandhi's stature peaks.
- **The settlement — Shimla (July 1972):**

- **Indira Gandhi and Z.A. Bhutto** meet at Shimla; both agree to settle disputes peacefully and respect the ceasefire line — now renamed the **Line of Control (LoC)** in Kashmir.
- **The lasting terms:** the LoC vocabulary and bilateral-negotiation principle flow from this agreement — quote both in treaty questions.

India's Nuclear Programme: From Peaceful Atom to Pokhran

- **The foundation (1940s-60s):**
  - **Atomic Energy Commission, 1948** — Nehru and **Homi Bhabha** build the nuclear estate early: research reactors, the Bhabha Atomic Research Centre (the old Tata Institute renamed 1967), nuclear power stations planned for a power-starved economy.
  - **The doctrine:** atoms for peace and development — India's nuclear identity BEGAN civilian.
- **The shock context:**
  - **1962's defeat, 1965's war, China's 1964 nuclear test** — the strategic neighbourhood turned nuclear and hostile within a decade; the bomb debate entered Indian politics.
  - **The NPT (1968):** a treaty dividing the world into nuclear "haves" (who keep their weapons) and "have-nots" (who renounce them forever). **India refused to sign** — the inequality was permanent and unacceptable; the same logic later rejected the CTBT.
- **Pokhran-I — 18 May 1974:**
  - **The event:** India detonates its first device at **Pokhran, Rajasthan** — codename **Smiling Buddha**.
  - **The official line:** a **PEACEFUL NUCLEAR EXPLOSION** — a capability demonstration, not a weapons announcement. The distinction is the exact phrase examiners hunt.
  - **The aftermath:** technology sanctions from the West; India settles into its long "nuclear ambiguity" — no arsenal declared, option preserved, universal disarmament still demanded.
  - **Looking forward:** Pokhran-II (May 1998) ends the ambiguity — but that belongs to the later chapters of the book.

Shifting Alliances: How India Moved in a Moving World

- **The 1950s — courted by both camps:**
  - Soviet steel plants (Bhilai), American wheat (PL-480), Western and Eastern technology — non-alignment maximised India's take from both sides.
  - **Pakistan's counter-move:** joining US pacts — **SEATO (1954)** and **CENTO** — American arms and bases, which pushed India defensively closer to Moscow for equipment.
- **The 1960s — the tilt becomes visible:**
  - **1962:** the US and UK airlift small arms during the China war — a flash of Western partnership.

- **1965:** the US arms embargo hits India (dependent on Western gear) harder than Soviet-equipped Pakistan; the **USSR brokers Tashkent** — Moscow is now the reliable partner.
- **Soviet arms and the veto:** Moscow's UN vetoes shield India on Kashmir through the decade.

- **1971 — the formal shift:**
  - The **Indo-Soviet Treaty** (above) hardens friendship into commitment for twenty years — the defining alliance fact of the era and the answer to "shifting alliance" questions.
  - **The evaluation line to quote:** the shift was **responsive, not ideological** — each Indian move answered a rival's move (US-Pakistan pacts → India-Soviet arms; 1971's US-China tilt → the treaty). Non-alignment adapted to a changed world rather than dying.

THE THREE WARS ON ONE LINE EACH

- **1962:** China — border shock — ceasefire 21 Nov 1962; Aksai Chin lost; Menon resigns.
- **1965:** Pakistan — Gibraltar fails — Tashkent 10 Jan 1966; Shastri dies; status quo restored.
- **1971:** Pakistan — Bangladesh liberation — 16 Dec 1971 surrender; Shimla 1972 creates the LoC.

Key Facts & Terms: One-Stop Revision

INDIA'S EXTERNAL RELATIONS — EVERY FACT ON ONE PAGE

Term / fact	Meaning / statement	Exam use
Non-alignment	No bloc membership; independent judgment on each issue — NOT neutrality	Definition-precision questions
NAM founders	Nehru, Nasser, Tito, Sukarno, Nkrumah	Person-listing questions
Bandung 1955 / Belgrade 1961	Afro-Asian conference / first NAM summit	Milestone matching
Panchsheel	Five co-existence principles, 29 April 1954, signed with China	Principle-listing questions
Commonwealth 1949	Republic membership without dominion status	Nehruvian-first questions
Tibet 1950 / Dalai Lama 1959	China absorbs Tibet; its leader takes asylum in India	Ladder-rung questions

Term / fact	Meaning / statement	Exam use
Aksai Chin	Ladakh sector; China's road built through it; retained by China after 1962	Territory questions
McMahon Line	The NEFA (Arunachal) boundary China rejects	Border-vocabulary questions
1962 war	20 Oct attacks on two fronts; Menon resigns; 21 Nov ceasefire	War-chain questions
Operation Gibraltar	Pakistan's 1965 infiltration into Kashmir	Operation-matching
1965 war	Khem Karan tank battles; India drives toward Lahore; status quo restored	War-chain questions
Tashkent Agreement	10 Jan 1966, Soviet-brokered; Shastri dies there 11 Jan	Treaty-date questions
Operation Searchlight	Pakistan's 25 Mar 1971 crackdown on East Pakistan	Trigger questions
Indo-Soviet Treaty	Aug 1971; 20 years of peace, friendship and cooperation	"shifting alliance" questions
Bangladesh	16 Dec 1971 — Dhaka falls, 93,000 prisoners surrender	War-outcome questions
Shimla Agreement	July 1972; Indira-Bhutto; ceasefire line becomes the LoC	Treaty-matching
Atomic Energy Commission	1948; Homi Bhabha; civilian nuclear estate	Foundation questions
NPT 1968	Have/have-not treaty; India REFUSES to sign; CTBT later too	Treaty-stance questions
Pokhran-I	18 May 1974; "Smiling Buddha"; official phrase: peaceful nuclear explosion	Year-and-phrase questions
SEATO-CENTO	Pakistan's US pacts of 1954/1950s — the push factor for India's Soviet tilt	Alliance questions

Common Errors & Special Cases

THE TRAPS THIS UNIT SETS — READ BEFORE THE MOCK

The rule you assume	The twist	The trap in the question
"Non-aligned = neutral"	India judged each issue independently and TOOK SIDES (1971)	Definition traps
"Panchsheel was signed with the USSR"	Partner: CHINA, 1954 — the war eight years later is the irony	Partner-matching
"1965 ended with territory gained"	Tashkent restored the status quo — no border changed	Outcome precision
"The US brokered Tashkent"	The USSR brokered it — and hosted it	Broker-matching
"India tested a nuclear BOMB in 1974"	Official line: a PEACEFUL NUCLEAR EXPLOSION — the weapons phase is 1998	Phrase precision
"India signed the NPT"	India REFUSED (1968) — discriminatory have/have-not structure	Treaty-stance traps
"The Indo-Soviet Treaty came after the 1971 war"	Signed in AUGUST 1971 — BEFORE December's war; it deterred intervention	Sequence questions
"Shimla created Bangladesh"	Shimla (1972) settled the AFTERMATH — the LoC; Bangladesh was born Dec 1971	Treaty-outcome pairing

The 60-Second Self-Test

Cover the answers, say each one aloud, then check. If any answer takes longer than ten seconds, revisit that section.

- **The five Panchsheel principles?** → Sovereignty respect, non-aggression, non-interference, equality-mutual benefit, peaceful co-existence (1954, with China).
- **Name NAM's founding five and first summit.** → Nehru, Nasser, Tito, Sukarno, Nkrumah — Belgrade 1961.

- **The two fronts of the 1962 war?** → Aksai Chin (Ladakh) and the McMahon Line (NEFA); China attacked 20 Oct 1962; Menon resigned.
- **1965's chain in one breath?** → Kutch skirmishes → Operation Gibraltar → September war → Tashkent (10 Jan 1966) → Shastri dies.
- **Why did 80 lakh refugees matter in 1971?** → Searchlight's crackdown sent them to India — the emergency that forced Delhi's hand.
- **The Indo-Soviet Treaty: when and why?** → August 1971, BEFORE the war — 20 years; it deterred US-China intervention.
- **What happened on 16 December 1971 and in July 1972?** → Dhaka falls (Bangladesh born); Shimla Agreement renames the ceasefire line the Line of Control.
- **Pokhran-I: date, codename, official phrase?** → 18 May 1974; Smiling Buddha; "peaceful nuclear explosion".

The Whole Chapter in One Picture

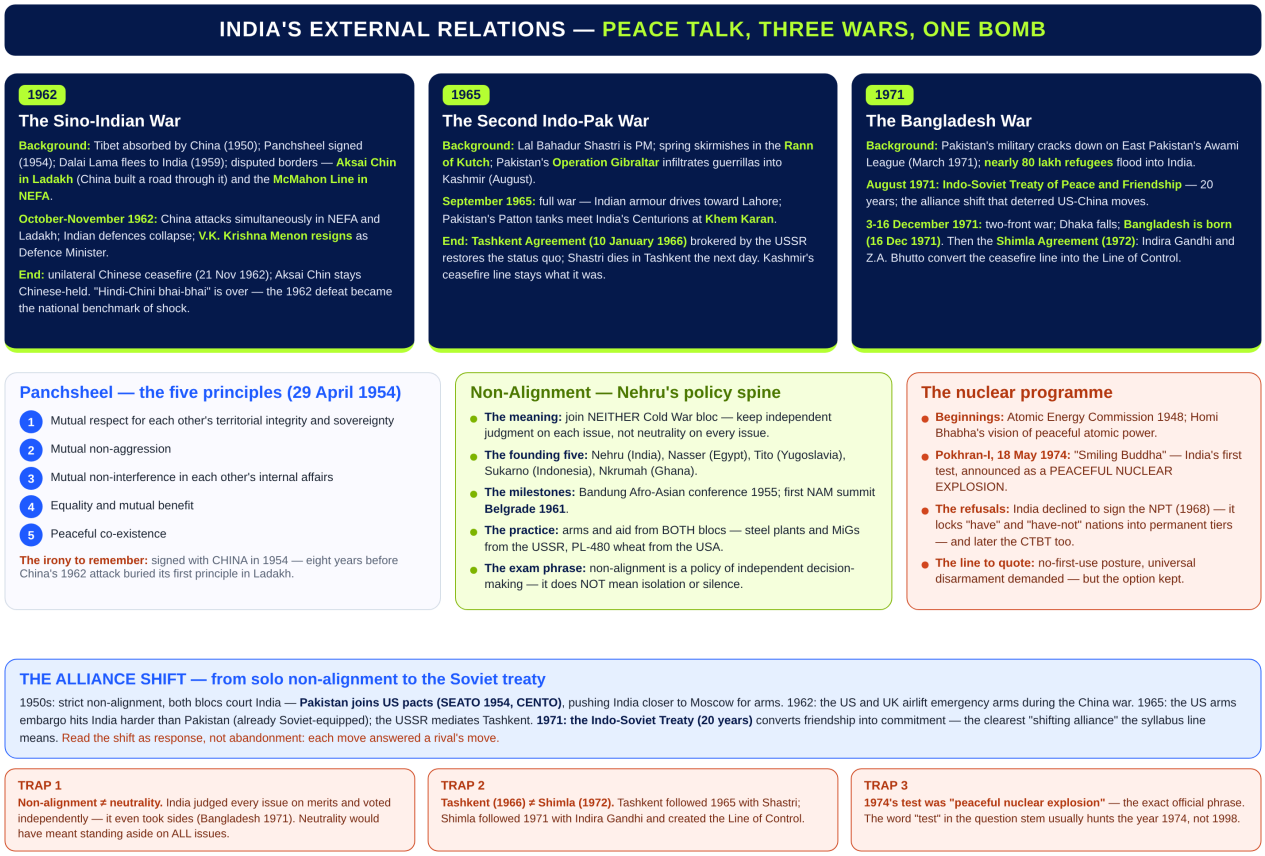


Figure 1: External relations on one board: the three wars as cause-war-treaty chains, Panchsheel's five principles, the NAM spine, the nuclear card, the alliance shift and the traps between them.



Figure 2: Chapter mindmap: Nehru's policy, the China collapse, the Pakistan wars, shifting alliances, the nuclear programme and the syllabus map — with the traps that catch most students.

Practice Questions (Exam Pattern)

Ten questions in the CUET UG style. Attempt all of them — the paper gives +5 for each correct answer and −1 for every incorrect answer.

Q1. The Panchsheel Agreement of 1954 was signed between India and:

(A) the Soviet Union
(B) China
(C) the United States
(D) Nepal

Q2. The first summit of the Non-Aligned Movement was held in 1961 at:

(A) Bandung
(B) Cairo
(C) Belgrade
(D) Jakarta

Q3. During the 1962 Sino-Indian war, the Indian Defence Minister who resigned was:

(A) Y.B. Chavan
(B) V.K. Krishna Menon
(C) S.K. Patil
(D) Morarji Desai

Q4. The Prime Minister of India during the 1965 war with Pakistan was:

(A) Jawaharlal Nehru **(B)** Indira Gandhi
(C) Morarji Desai **(D)** Lal Bahadur Shastri

Q5. The Treaty of Peace, Friendship and Cooperation of August 1971 was signed between India and:

(A) the United States **(B)** the Soviet Union
(C) Bangladesh **(D)** China

Q6. Bangladesh came into existence as an independent country in:

(A) March 1971 **(B)** August 1971
(C) December 1971 **(D)** July 1972

Q7. India's first nuclear test at Pokhran (codename "Smiling Buddha") was conducted in:

(A) 1968 **(B)** 1971
(C) 1974 **(D)** 1998

Q8. India refused to sign the Nuclear Non-Proliferation Treaty (NPT) mainly because it considered the treaty:

(A) discriminatory between nuclear "haves" and "have-nots" **(B)** technically unworkable
(C) economically costly **(D)** hostile to peaceful nuclear power

Q9. The Shimla Agreement (1972) between Indira Gandhi and Z.A. Bhutto renamed the Kashmir ceasefire line as the:

(A) Durand Line **(B)** Radcliffe Line
(C) McMahon Line **(D)** Line of Control

Q10. In the 1971 war, the Instrument of Surrender was signed in Dhaka by General A.A.K. Niazi before the Indian commander:

(A) Jagjit Singh Aurora **(B)** Sam Manekshaw
(C) K.M. Cariappa **(D)** A.S. Kalkat

Detailed Solutions

Each solution shows the reasoning, not just the verdict — cover the answer line, attempt the question, then compare.

Sol. Q1. Panchsheel — 29 April 1954 — formed the preamble of the India-China Tibet trade agreement. The Soviet pacts came in 1971; Nepal is a neighbouring treaty partner of a different kind.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q2. Belgrade, Yugoslavia, September 1961 — the first NAM summit of 25 countries. Bandung (1955) was the Afro-Asian gathering that PREPARED the ground — a favourite near-miss option.

Answer: (C)

Sol. Q3. V.K. Krishna Menon — Nehru's closest defence aide — resigned on 6 November 1962 as the military collapse peaked. Y.B. Chavan succeeded him.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q4. Lal Bahadur Shastri led India through 1965 ("Jai Jawan Jai Kisan"). Nehru died in 1964; Indira Gandhi took over only in January 1966 after Shastri's death at Tashkent.

Answer: (D)

Sol. Q5. The Indo-Soviet Treaty of Peace, Friendship and Cooperation — August 1971, twenty years — signed BEFORE the December war to deter US-China intervention.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q6. 16 December 1971 — the day General Niazi signed the surrender in Dhaka. March 1971 marks the crackdown that STARTED the crisis; July 1972 is Shimla.

Answer: (C)

Sol. Q7. 18 May 1974 — Pokhran-I, codename "Smiling Buddha", officially a "peaceful nuclear explosion". 1968 is the NPT year and 1998 is Pokhran-II — the deliberate bookend distractors.

Answer: (C)

Sol. Q8. India's stated objection: the NPT froze a permanent divide — the weapons states keep theirs, everyone else renounces forever. The refusal logic also covered the CTBT later.

Answer: (A)

Sol. Q9. The Line of Control — the 1971 ceasefire line renamed at Shimla. The Durand, Radcliffe and McMahon Lines are colonial-era boundaries — classic distractors.

Answer: (D)

Sol. Q10. Niazi surrendered to Lt Gen Jagjit Singh Aurora, GOC-in-C Eastern Command — the alliance with the Mukti Bahini was Aurora's building. Manekshaw was the Army Chief who planned and timed the campaign.

Answer: (A)

Wrong-Answer Clinic — the one-line corrections

Dropped marks above? Find your slip here and rewrite the corrected rule in your own words.

If you answered...	Your slip was...	The corrected rule, in one line
Q2 option A	Giving Bandung the summit title	Bandung 1955 = Afro-Asian conference; Belgrade 1961 = first NAM summit
Q4 option B	Starting Indira's reign early	1965 belongs to Shastri; Indira Gandhi becomes PM in January 1966
Q6 option A	Dating Bangladesh from the crackdown	March 1971 = Operation Searchlight; independence = 16 December 1971
Q7 option D	Jumping to Pokhran-II	Pokhran-I = 1974 ("Smiling Buddha"); Pokhran-II = 1998
Q9 option B	Grabbing the nearest famous line	Radcliffe = India-Pakistan border (1947); LoC = the 1972 Shimla rename
Q10 option B	Crediting the chief with the surrender table	Manekshaw planned the war; Aurora received the surrender in Dhaka

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